

My design intent

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21 July 2024

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When level designing, I start and loop through a few key points to construct my level, adjusting and rejecting designs as I continue to progress. While not always in this order, but as a general guideline, with some of the neighboring points swapping with each other depending on the priority.

- Restriction – What are the specifications and/or limitations
- Ideation/storyboard – What is the general idea intended
- Mechanics – What are the main draws to be used in the level
- Environmental – How should the environment be used
- Thematic – How do we make the general level match thematically
- Personalize/Humanize – How do we add smaller details

Restrictions



When starting with the level design, the overall scope of the level must be accounted for to ensure that the level design makes sense. While video games tend not to include, hardware limitation was important as well. As part of the assignment requirements, designing based on said restrictions also helps narrow the scope of the level, forcing me to make efficient use of the given resources, or to have creative usage of said restrictions and not to over scope with a limited time given.



Difficulty is another restriction that must be considered for the level design's approach, the cadence, autonomy and allowance of mistakes affect the level's path, but also later can be involved in the storytelling and environment.

Ideation/Storyboard



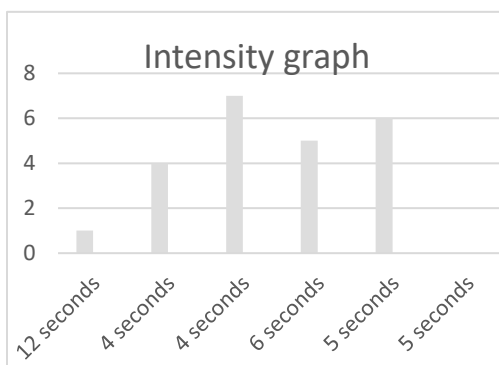
After laying the restrictions, creating the purpose of the level is important. Why are we building a level? Depending on the game, it could be due to storytelling, teaching players something or perhaps for the player's fun. My approach is to try whatever could come to mind first. This idea would later need revision to ensure coherency.

Rejected ideas also help build the foundation of restrictions and what I can currently build, whilst also giving a premise for future ideas. For example, a throne room as a house seems impossible, however with the story of a selfish king "stealing" his servant's house, an idea of such a level can come more into fruition. If the mechanics took priority, then the storytelling can assist with transition between cadences.

Mechanics



Another approach towards how a level is designed is what the player will be intended to be doing. Sometimes a hybrid of choosing a theme and a mechanic is used as the desired direction of the level's design. Ensuring a good cadence also helps to enable story changes, or to see if it can fit within the set restrictions. The



mechanics allow for expression of the story as well, which also can assist in contributing towards a more detailed idea that allows for a more integrated story with the gameplay. Reviewing the intensity of mechanics also help gauge the difficulty and thus the restrictions, thus help make the level more enjoyable for players.

Environment

After the main theme of the level is decided, the environment comes into play. The way the story or mechanics are expressed within the background. It helps detail how the story occurs, for example the ravine climbing earthquake, or it expresses the possible upcoming intensity for the player, the town attack. It informs the player without disrupting the flow of gameplay as much.



However, a balance between the storytelling, difficulty and the mechanics needs to be considered. Noise from the background can distract players from mechanics or objectives. For example, in an early version of one of my levels, a boss room was confusing for first-time players, as the action occurring distracted them from knowing where or what to do. So, to improve the clarity of the level, I deviated from the original theme to improve the contrast between the environment, still preserving the general idea of the factory. This also allowed for additional guidance for players within the restrictions of the level setup.

Thematic integration



When considering implementation of environmental storytelling, I would research where, why and how things are used. Besides knowing if they have replacements, the rarity and social norm should be

considered as well. For example, Ludicolo is a Pokémon that is seen as friendly and can entertain, making sense for their presence within a hotel, the environment of the map I made is a desert, which leads to Ludicolo to be much rarer to be found, which is why it is only one of two establishments to use them. But careful research for consideration must also be given to the implementation to avoid



appropriation. For example, there is a Pokémon taxi system that has a Corviknight to carry people about. However, if another Pokémon known as or that can evolve into Tinkaton, considered their natural predator, is present within the area, it would be considered too dangerous for Corviknight to ferry people about, and thus the area must use different Pokémon, as shown through my map.

Personalize/Humanize



When the opportunity comes after iterating through the loop of key points to ensure consistency of the level design, I add towards the story telling by adding extra activities that the player could do if they explored areas that seem not to reward the usual. These also add towards the immersion of the level in my opinion.

Conclusion

With most of my work done this semester, I have realized that within a thematic scope, I am able to easily detail and keep the mechanics immersive. I felt that I was good at expressing the theme but was struggling to document and explain more complex areas, but my engineering background allowed me to use alternatives to either explain or justify specific thematic choices and also to keep the realism in mind for buildings.